

THREE PARTS, WRITE YOURS TONIGHT

The pitch that got me in with no PM experience

Before anyone gives you a PM interview, somebody asks what you do, and you have to explain why a person with your background should get a job you've never held.

What worked for me was three parts about myself. I said them to a Microsoft CVP at a conference, with no PM experience and no case studies, and he told me to talk to his recruiter.

Here's the structure, why each part is there, and how to write yours.

1 Part one, the hardest thing you actually own

Open with the most technically specific thing you do, said plainly enough that someone outside your field can tell what it does.

Here's how I opened: "I'm currently at Intel and I do hardware validation engineering. I work on the platform controller hub, which is how all the IPs on a chip, SATA, eMMC, SD card, connect back into the CPU. We're what enables the CPU to do everything it does, because the CPU is just a calculator that does calculations really, really fast."

I named the component and then said what it does in a sentence or two, so anybody listening could follow it without knowing hardware.

EXAMPLE

Write one sentence naming the hardest real thing you work on. Then write one sentence on what it does, in words your parents would follow.

WHY THIS MATTERS: the person you're talking to hears that you do hard technical work before they hear that you want to change jobs.

2 Part two, the unpaid proof of the other half

Now show the thing you do that nobody pays you for.

For me that was Alexa: "On my weekends I build Alexa skills in Java, and I have a couple of skills in the store that people use."

Anybody can say they're interested in a new field. Something you built on your own time is proof you can point to, and the person listening can go and look it up.

It can be small, as long as it's real and it's yours.

EXAMPLE

Name one thing you built, ran, wrote or organized on your own time that's closer to the job you want than the job you have. A side project, a community you run, a newsletter, a product teardown you posted.

WHY THIS MATTERS: by the time you say what role you want in part three, the person listening has already heard proof that you've been doing the work.

3 Part three, the role you want

End by naming the role that needs both of the things you just said.

Mine was: "I'm not interested in hardware or software, but both, and I want to be the PM who brings them together." Then I said why: "My value is in understanding how things are made. I believe having the experience in both spaces makes me well equipped to handle the problems we deal with in the PM space."

EXAMPLE

Fill in the blanks: "I'm not interested in [what you do at work] or [what you do on your own time], but both, and I want to be the [role] who brings them together."

WHY THIS MATTERS: the CVP said, "I don't really know what you're about, but I can tell that you're passionate and interested in the PM space. Why don't you talk to my recruiter?" I think the passion is what got me that referral.

4 What to leave out

Leave out the apology. My pitch never said "I know I don't have PM experience."

I also didn't ask for anything, whether that's a referral, a job or a favor. The CVP brought up the recruiter on his own.

EXAMPLE

Write your three parts, then cross out every sentence that apologizes, hedges or asks for something. Read what's left out loud.

WHY THIS MATTERS: if you bring up the gap, the conversation becomes about the gap.

5 Attach a number to yourself

The pitch as I remember it didn't have a number in it. It's 2026 now and a lot has changed, and this is the part I'd add.

The way I see it, we're all salesmen, and the thing we're selling is ourselves and our effort. A company hires you because it believes you'll bring in more than you cost. So attach a dollar number to yourself, and let that number speak when you talk to people.

EXAMPLE

Finish this sentence before any conversation: "Because of my work, my team makes or saves \$X." Use a real figure from your current job, even a small one.

WHY THIS MATTERS: when a number speaks for you, people can feel that you're the one with the solution for them.

6 Say it out loud before you need it

Practice the three parts before the event, so they're ready when you're standing in front of somebody who can help.

EXAMPLE

Say your three parts out loud ten times. Then say them to one person who doesn't work in your field, and watch which part they stop following. Fix that part.

WHY THIS MATTERS: I went to AfroTech planning to talk to every single person I could, and the one who helped me was a CVP at a Microsoft event on a yacht. Have the pitch ready before your first conversation of the day.

Three parts: what you're deep in at work, what you do unpaid that proves the other half, and the role that needs both.

Write yours tonight and say it out loud tomorrow.